



COCO GAUFF'S SHOT VARIETY AND FOOT SPEED BROKE DOWN ARYNA SABALENKA'S POWER-BALL GAME AND POISE

Alcaraz had performed better on the big points, most notably the three championship points. Ultimately, the difference was belief. "I just believe all the time," Alcaraz said. "I never have doubts about myself, even in those match points down. I thought just one point at a time."

GAUFF OUTDUELS SABALENKA TO WIN FIRST FRENCH OPEN

Although Coco Gauff's 6-7, 6-2, 6-4 victory over Aryna Sabalenka never matched the men's final in sustained excellence, it certainly did in closeness, unpredictability and excitement. Whether that was due to the windy conditions, nerves in their first Roland Garros final, or their even rivalry — 1-1 on clay and 5-5 overall — wild fluctuations turned this duel into an intriguing test of will as much as skill.

The first set alone saw eight service breaks. Sabalenka, who had won 19 of her last 20 Grand Slam matches, including her stunning 7-6(1), 4-6, 6-0 semifinal victory over four-time French champion Iga Swiatek, seemed like that same irresistible force when she broke Gauff's serve with a forehand volley winner for 2-1 and a vicious forehand serve return winner for 4-1.

When the 5'11" Belarusian power hitter raced to a 40-love lead in the next game, she looked like the same player who steamrolled Swiatek in the final set two days earlier. The same player about whom *Tennis Channel* analyst Prakash Amritraj said, "When she plays her best, another player can't beat her."

Unless the other player is Gauff. The resilient American reeled off five straight points to secure her first

service break. Two games later, Gauff broke again on her fifth break point with a backhand passing shot that the rattled Sabalenka misjudged and let go by. During the huge momentum swing, Sabalenka swept 16 of the first 23 points, while Gauff grabbed 14 of the next 20.

Gauff's fighting spirit

With Sabalenka serving for the set at 5-4, Gauff escaped two set points and then broke serve on her fifth break point. "That's the fighting spirit we've known so well from Gauff," said Davenport. The topsy-turvy set had two more service breaks. Sabalenka raised her arms in exultation after a forehand volley winner put her briefly ahead 6-5. In the next game on break point, Gauff countered with the shot of the match. The Florida Flash sprinted to a Sabalenka overhead and drilled a sensational backhand down-the-line passing shot winner. No lead was safe. In the tie-break, Gauff raced to a 4-1 advantage highlighted by two backhand winners. Sabalenka responded, showing off her power and finesse to seize the last four points with winners. An 84-mph backhand service return made it 4-5, a ferocious down-the-line backhand 5-5, a cross-court forehand volley 6-5, and a feathery forehand drop volley 7-5.

But Gauff had seen this movie before. Even starred in it. She had lost the opening set in the 2023 US Open final against Sabalenka and pulled the match out in three thrilling sets for her first Grand Slam crown. Gauff knew that if she could once again find the right balance between high-percentage offence and point-prolonging defence, she could induce many more errors from Sabalenka. As Stephens colourfully put it before the final, "Coco needs to run for her life, Aryna needs to keep her head."

The momentum shifted again. Gauff's improved Western forehand delivered a cross-court winner for a service break and 1-0 lead. When she held serve at love for 2-0, Sabalenka started fuming and vented to her camp. Were the ghosts of heart-breaking three-set losses at Majors — such as that US Open final

extreme athleticism of a football wide receiver and a baseball shortstop, Alcaraz leapt laterally through no-man's-land, intercepted it, and created a jaw-dropping forehand cross-court volley winner. "He does the seemingly impossible on the court," John said.

The charismatic Spaniard clinched the match tiebreak 10-2 with yet another super shot — an unforgettable forehand winner à la Nadal — to finish one of the greatest comebacks in tennis history.

After 5 hours and 29 minutes — the second longest in time for a Grand Slam final — Sinner had won one more point, 193 to 192. But